There are sixteen Hindu and Jain temples at Osian, which is 32 miles away from Jodhpur. The Jain temple at Mount Abu has a white marble hall and a central dome of 11 concentric rings and richly carved vaulted ceiling and pillars.

Temple at Osian

Contribution of Palas to Culture

The Palas were adherents to the Mahayana school of Buddhism. They were generous patrons of Buddhist temples and the famous universities of Nalanda and Vikramashila. It was through their missionaries that Buddhism was established in Tibet. The celebrated Buddhist monk, Atisha (981-1054), who reformed Tibetan Buddhism, was the president of the Vikramashila monastery. The Palas also maintained cordial relations with the Hindu-Buddhist state of the Shailendras of Sumatra and Java.

Under Pala patronage, a distinctive school of art arose, called Pala art or **Eastern Indian art.** Pala artistic style flourished in present-day states of Bihar and West Bengal, and also in present-day Bangladesh. It was chiefly represented by bronze sculptures and palm-leaf paintings, celebrating the Buddha and other divinities. The Pala bronze sculptures from this area played an important part in the spread of Indian culture in Southeast Asia.

Palm Leaf Painting of Palas

Advent of Islam

Islam as a religious faith originated at Mecca in Arabia. The founder of Islam was Prophet Muhammad. The followers of Islam are called Muslims. An Islamic state, especially the one ruled by a single religious and political leader, was known as 'Caliphate'. Caliph means a representative of the Prophet Muhammad. Two early Caliphates were 'Umayyads' and the 'Abbasids'. Both the Umayyads and the Abbasids expanded their rule separately by their conquests and by preaching the principles of Islam.

In the 8th century India, the Arab presence appeared in the form of a Muslim army that conquered the Sind. But their further expansion was made impossible by the kings of Gangetic plains and the Deccan. By the end of the 9th century, with the decline of the Abbasid Caliphate, the Arab garrisons in India and elsewhere threw off Caliph's control and began to rule independently.

The Turkish governor, Alp-Tegin, was one among them whose capital was Ghazni (Afghanistan). His successor and son-in-law Sabuktigin wanted to conquer India from the north-west. But only his son Mahmud succeeded in this endeavour.

Mahmud of Ghazni (A.D. (CE) 997 -1030)

Mahmud is said to have conducted 17 raids into India. At that time, North India was divided into number of small kingdoms. One of them was

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